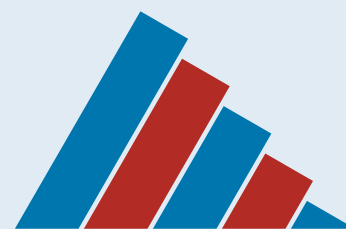


Takeaways For Building An Employment Outcome Data System In Your State



State Employment
Leadership Network

Many states are pursuing new uses of data and the need to get a better handle on outcomes for the resource investment being made. The June 2014 SELN Data Users' Group meeting focused on Ohio's Department of Developmental Disabilities (DODD) building, implementing, and using a new Employment First outcome data system. DODD will analyze and report on the data collected to identify policies and practices that lead to successful employment outcomes for individuals with developmental disabilities. The meeting recording (link at right) includes a display of screens illustrating how DODD's system will work. Based on work the SELN team is supporting in several states the following takeaways are offered when considering a priority goal related to data systems development.

Listen to the discussions

Webinar recording
(59 minutes)

Audio recording

1. **Decide what questions you want to answer.** This will guide the strategic goals and work needed to design a new data system or modify an existing one.
2. **Decide what kind of system it will be.** You'll need to choose between three options: a) adding to an existing, stand-alone data system, b) creating a new stand-alone data system, or c) integrating data points (or variables) within a management information system. All three take work, and the effort must be customized to what is most beneficial, but also doable, in your state.
3. **Know your capacity for using what is collected.** This may involve prioritizing the data points to collect, and eliminating nonessential ones. Many states set out to collect a long list of data points, only to find the task is overwhelming for those submitting the data, or the state is not prepared to report out all that is learned. Additional data points can be phased in over time as the system grows in use.
4. **Determine the political will needed to support data collection, management, and use/reporting.** Allies are critical, as is having the buy-in of those who will be supervising data collection throughout the state. Involve a wide range of staff from program/content areas, information technology, fiscal, and other funders such as Medicaid. Invite them with a collaborative spirit, including materials and dialogue to reinforce your shared goals and the business case for strong data management in your state.
5. **Discuss the reporting and sharing options,** how the data will be displayed, how public it will be, and when it will be shared. Making data public is powerful, but takes thoughtful planning to be manageable and useful for your audiences.

A successful employment outcome data system must...

1. Reflect the result of the investment (time, money, staffing) your system is achieving in outcomes, not just reporting on service data.
2. Identify your goals and tell audiences where you are going.
3. Be based on shared or common definitions of employment types across the state.
4. Communicate the importance of employment as a core outcome.
5. Organize a discussion of what is working well or needed changes, such as new processes for creating contracts with providers and managed care organizations.

The SELN is a joint program of the Institute for Community Inclusion at UMass Boston and the National Association of State Directors of Developmental Disabilities Services.

To learn more about SELN, visit

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